

IBM airbags notebook

IBM recently launched two ThinkPad notebooks—the ThinkPad R50 and the ThinkPad T41—with a new data protection feature. The Active Protection System technology is somewhat similar to the one used to deploy air bags during a car crash. A device containing a microchip detects whether



the notebook is falling or being dropped, and accordingly, freezes the hard drive's read and write head until the system shows it has stabilised.

Robert Enochs, IBM's segment marketing manager for the ThinkPad P Series, expects the new technology to bring about a decrease in warranty expenses. Initially, IBM will incorporate the technology only in the two new ThinkPad models, incorporating the feature into other models in the future.

Vying for your ears online

Music lovers seem to have the gods smiling down on them; at least on those who play their music on computers. Apple Computer is to expand its online iTunes Music Store service to Windows-based computers. Sony too announced the launch of an online music



service, while RealNetworks declared an add-on download component to its Rhapsody service. Napster also launched its new service, Napster 2.0, which is very different from the original Napster. It now charges only 99 cents for a single tune to anyone who downloads its free software. At \$10 a month, one can listen to an unlimited number of streaming songs.

Similarly, MusicMatch and BuyMusic are operating online music download services that are aimed at Windows users.

Apple said earlier that it had sold 10 million songs through the iTunes store, serving just the relatively small Macintosh market. According to RealNetworks, subscribers listened to more than 21 million songs in the month of September, representing a 30 per cent jump in usage since August 2003.

Applaud the King's Return

As the visual effects work that they approached Weta in

the *Lord of the Rings* trilogy enters its final leg, the baton will be carried home by none other than Mumbai-based Applause Entertainment. The final part of the epic, *Return of the King*, is expected to premiere in December 2003. The prestigious contract will be executed in Applause's Mumbai office and will be headed by N. Madhusudhanan. The movie's director, Peter Jackson, owns New Zealand-based Weta Productions, who did the effects for the first two prequels. Applause Entertainment's Chief Operating Officer Anshumaan Swamy said



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DBTEL Cells in India

DBTEL, a Taiwanese telecom company, plans to launch 10 to 11 cell phones by the end of November 2003. Although it has yet to reveal the price range of the new handsets, Lewis Tu, director of DBTEL, indicated that the low-end models would cost roughly around Rs 4,000 to 4,500.

Referring to India as the

second largest market share, the DBTEL Group showed intentions of establishing a subsidiary or a branch office in India in the near future.

Currently though, it has appointed Chennai-based Munoth Communication Ltd as its distributor. Tu said that DBTEL plans to capture 20 per cent of the Indian market share by the end of 2004.



Spam

Guiding spam

Three of America's top advertising trade groups have come together to formulate guidelines that will legitimise e-mail-based marketing messages. The groups claimed that since spam was killing the potential of e-mail marketing, it made sense to have all marketers adhere to guidelines that would ultimately help a customer differentiate between legitimate commercial e-mail and spam. The guidelines, being self regulating, are pretty interesting: some of the nine listed guidelines include providing a valid e-mail address that belongs to the sender, a clear and reliable option for customers to let themselves exit from the list, and that e-mail addresses should be added with the consent of the owner, and addresses should not be sold to or shared with other parties without prior approval.

Spam smarts

A study conducted by DoubleClick Inc found out that 65 per cent of consumers delete spam without reading it and 4 per cent read it to see if it's of any use. The numbers compare favourably with those of last year, when 60 per cent deleted it and 5 per cent read it. DoubleClick says that consumers are using different techniques to combat spam—ranging from bulk mail folders, to separate e-mail addresses. In another study by the Pew Internet and American Life Project, respondents believed that spam was one of three top priorities for their companies.